



STRENGTHENING PUBLIC MEDIA BROADCASTING TO FIGHT DISINFORMATION?

A case of German-speaking countries

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Content

- Characteristics of the Media Landscape of German-speaking countries (Democratic Corporatist Model)
- Rise of Far-Right Parties and Disinformation
- How do Far-Right Media Outlets or Parties Distribute Disinformation?
- How does Public Service Media help Containing Disinformation?
- Possible Future Research

Democratic Corporatist Model

- Austria, Germany, Switzerland → Democratic Corporatist Model (Hallin & Mancini, 2004)
- Rooted in the history of the welfare state: Media is viewed as a social institution for the public good, not just private commodity.
- Core Characteristics:
 - *High Journalistic Professionalism*
 - *Political Parallelism*
 - *Central Role of Public Broadcasting (media as social institution)*

Democratic Corporatist Model

- Refining the Model (Brüggemann et al., 2014)
 - *Classification of Austria, Germany, Switzerland (and the UK) as distinct **Central European** dimension*
- Key Differences to the Nordic Model:
 - *Stricter regulation of media ownership*
 - *Less inclusive press markets → strong public service media*

Rise of Far-Right Parties and Disinformation

- Economic Factors (Noury & Roland, 2020)
 - *Impact of the Great Recession (2008) and Globalization*
 - *Predominantly on the working class → left out by established left-wing parties*
- Cultural Factors (Noury & Roland, 2020)
 - *2015 Migration Crisis → identity politics (“native culture threatened”)*

→ Right-wing parties use populism to transform economic shocks and anti-immigration sentiment into systematic distrust

Rise of Far-Right Parties and Disinformation

- Disinformation (Bennet & Livingston, 2018)
 - *Strategic, intentional spread of falsehoods to advance political goals*
 - *=/= Misinformation (accidental errors)*
- Disinformation intertwined with right-wing parties (Bennet & Livingston, 2018)
 - *Usage of social media to distribute disinformation (migration, globalization. etc.)*
 - *Amplifier effect (disinformation – amplification – reverberation)*

Rise of Far-Right Parties and Disinformation

- Democratic Corporatist Model as amplifier of far-right parties' regressive media?
 - *High journalistic standards and historical context lead traditional media to take a critical stance against far-right populism (Müller & Freudenthaler, 2022)*
 - *Germany has the highest number of identified regressive alternative outlets (Cazzamatta, 2025)*

→ “gatekeeping” by the DCM inadvertently drives right-wing ideology toward **alternative media infrastructure**

Rise of Far-Right Parties and Disinformation

- Austria: Mainstream Integration
 - *Unlike Germany's reliance on "outsider" media, Austrian right-wing narratives are often distributed directly through the Freedom Party (2019 part of Austrian government) (Müller & Freudenthaler, 2022)*
- Alternative outlets do not just focus on one issue; they build a comprehensive partisan worldview (Müller & Freudenthaler, 2022)
- Approximately 50% of all articles in these outlets are explicitly tied to right-wing ideology (Müller & Freudenthaler, 2022)

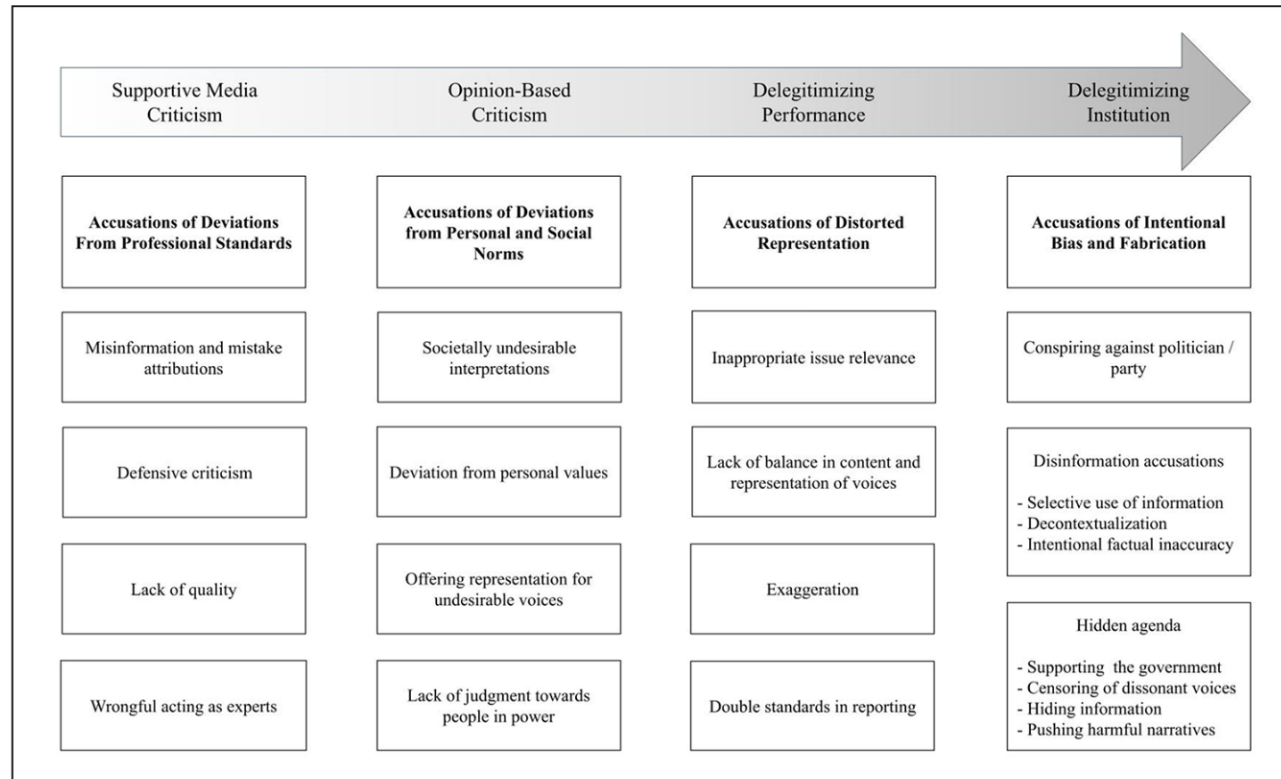


Figure 2. Typology of media criticism in the social media discourse of German politicians.

HOW DO FAR-RIGHT MEDIA OUTLETS OR PARTIES DISTRIBUTE DISINFORMATION?

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- Delegitimizing Institutions (Buttegereit et al., 2024):
 - *Qualitative content analysis using a grounded theory approach*
 - *Analysis of German politicians' tweets from 2015 to 2022*
- While criticism exists across the political spectrum, right-wing actors move beyond factual critique toward systematic delegitimization (attacking public broadcasting)
- Key narratives:
 - *Promoting conspiracy narratives that public service media is a mouthpiece of the government (→ the more people belief in conspiracy theories the more they are dissatisfied with democracy (Navarrete & Eder, 2026)*
 - *Information suppression*

HOW DO FAR-RIGHT MEDIA OUTLETS OR PARTIES DISTRIBUTE DISINFORMATION?

- Misinformation inside Public Broadcasting (Nenno, 2025):
 - *Explorative study of fact-checked claims within German Public Service Broadcasting news and talk shows*
 - *“mismatch” between the high standards of news programs and the content of talk shows*
- While news are highly resilient toward misinformation, talk shows often become entry points for misinformation by political elites.

How does Public Service Media help Containing Disinformation?

- Public broadcasting pivotal in combating disinformation (Sehl, 2024)
 - *Although public service media can be targets and platforms for misinformation, they are the most important actors in combating disinformation*
 - *To remain resilient, public broadcasting must move beyond traditional broadcasting and adopt active digital strategies*
 - Fact-Checking units
 - Platform monitoring: tracking disinformation

How does Public Service Media help Containing Disinformation?

- Public broadcasting pivotal in combating disinformation (Sehl, 2024)
 - *Public broadcasting needs to engage with younger audience on platforms where regressive media is the strongest*
 - *Gatekeeping role*
 - *In the democratic corporatist model, public service media has a normative duty to ensure an informed public*
- similarity to 민영 (2025): structural problem, gatekeeping role of the media

Possible Future Research

- Future research could explore how artificial intelligence can be employed in public broadcasting stations to fulfill their monitoring role as suggested by Sehl (2004).
- Furthermore, as public broadcasting is pivotal in fighting disinformation and conspiracy theories, future research should illuminate ways how public broadcasting can increase its viewership.
- Lastly, a comprehensive study on how disinformation in the democratic corporatist model possesses other characteristics in comparison to other models could help to employ solutions for disinformation.

Discussion Questions

1. In light of Sehl's (2024) research indicating the pivotal role of public service media and the fact that many people consume individualized content in Korea rather than public broadcasting, how can public broadcasting can become relevant again?
2. The case of German-speaking countries showed that high journalistic standards and a tradition that criticizes right-wing ideology can backfire into accelerating the rise of such parties, media outlets, and ideologies. In light of this, do you think we need less strict journalistic standards?
3. In a post-truth society and an increased algorithm-based media consumption, how can public service media and journalism fulfil their role in gatekeeping news?

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